and, in their retreat, they would seek revenge on the defenseless.

It was hard to see in the murky light, so she would need to bring the women out one by one to assess them.

“Olga, ask them who needs help first. They’ve been traveling together; they will know.”

Léa listened to Olga addressing the women, and she heard them answer back—their voices crackling with fear.

“They say help Anna, then Nadiya. Anna has a deep cut on her hand. Nadiya is with child.” Olga made the sign of the cross. “There’s a woman—no one knows her name—who they fear is dead but they’ve been too afraid to check.”

“Where is she?”

“At the back of the wagon on the left.”

Léa used the wall as a guide. Her eyes burned and watered. She found the woman, her hand cold and stiff. She didn’t need to take a pulse. “Olga, hand me a blanket from the platform.” She covered the woman and whispered a little prayer that she would now find peace.

She turned back to the rest of the women. “Anna, Anna?”

“*Da*,” came a deep voice. A strip of light crossed an older woman’s face, helping Léa find her in the darkness as she stumbled past the others.

A sharp, ammonia-like odor pierced the air. The wound on Anna’s hand had likely not been cleaned. Her body was warm to the touch, which meant an infection had set in. Anna was the priority. The sooner Josef could deal with her hand, the lower the risk of complications. “Come, let me help you outside.”

On the platform, she got a clearer look at Anna’s mangled hand: the digits were swollen and red, and pus gathered like drops of thick honey on the skin.

“Josef?” Léa smiled at Anna, trying to mask her worry so as not to send the woman into a panic. She turned to Olga. “Ask her if she’s in pain.”

“She says it throbs and burns. She’s afraid she’ll lose her hand.”

“Tell her not to be afraid. Josef, I need—”

“I’m here. Let me have a look.” Josef turned the woman’s hand over, examining the skin and pressing his fingers against the swollen, red palm. “Infection for sure. What’s her name?”

“Anna.” Léa rubbed her back, trying to reassure her.